

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Windy and cooler 42/26 • Tomorrow: Cold 38/22 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, FEBRUARY 17, 2025 • \$4

Trump's moves may lead to new health risk

Experts say cuts threaten U.S. ability to identify, respond to outbreaks

BY DAN DIAMOND
AND LENA H. SUN

In Atlanta, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention was told Friday to lay off an estimated 10 percent of its staff, including nearly an entire class of “disease detectives” — the infectious-disease experts charged with helping spot the next epidemic.

In West Texas, local officials warned about the spreading risk of measles, saying that an outbreak of the vaccine-preventable disease had doubled to 48 cases since early last week.

And in the Oval Office, President Donald Trump signed an executive order focused on ... coronavirus vaccination mandates in schools and universities. “President Trump is fulfilling his campaign promise: ‘I will not allow schools to impose COVID vaccine mandates,’” a White House fact sheet read. Even some GOP officials acknowledged that the order addresses an issue that is effectively moot: Almost all colleges and universities stopped requiring covid-19 vaccination after the public health emergency ended in May 2023, according to the American College Health Association.

Five years after a public health crisis rattled Trump's first administration, his second appears to be responding by rolling back the

SEE CDC ON A4

No trace of violence for some sent to Cuba

Records cast doubt on ‘worst of the worst’ label for Guantánamo arrivals

BY SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU,
ANA VANESSA HERRERO
AND MARÍA LUISA PAÚL

When the first flight of migrants arrived at Guantánamo Bay, Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem said they were “the worst of the worst.” Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth called them “high-threat” criminals who had crossed the border to bring “violence and mayhem to our communities.”

All were members of a Venezuelan gang called Tren de Aragua, the Trump administration said, invoking the name of a group the president mentions frequently to explain why a mass deportation is needed. Officials put them in a prison on the U.S. naval station in Cuba created for suspected terrorists after Sept. 11, 2001.

Little was known about the men when they were initially sent to Cuba. Human rights lawyers called Guantánamo a “legal black hole” and lambasted the U.S. government for not allowing them access to the migrants. But through photos released by DHS and accounts from family members, their names have begun to emerge.

SEE DEPORTATIONS ON A8

Rubio visits Jerusalem in first stop of Middle East tour



EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/POOL/REUTERS

Secretary of State Marco Rubio at the Yad Vashem Holocaust memorial in Jerusalem on Sunday, along with Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar, far left, and Yad Vashem chairman Dani Dayan, second from right. Rubio's visit was welcomed by Israeli officials; he is set to stop in Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates next. **Story, A9**

Once a unifier, Washington now divides Europe

Policymakers think U.S. is eager to split continent in Ukraine negotiations

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

MUNICH — When Russia invaded Ukraine three years ago, the United States helped whip Europe into a staunchly unified response. Now, U.S. leaders may be splitting Europe into pieces as President Donald Trump seeks to end the war, European leaders and policymakers say.

Vice President JD Vance and other top administration officials made their European debut last week, slashing their way through a continent of allies as they embraced far-right leaders, demanded access to mineral wealth and offered sympathy to the views of Russian President Vladimir Putin.

By the end of the week, European leaders found themselves potentially cut out of peace talks with Russia, facing down a trade war with Washington and scrambling to answer U.S. requests about how many troops they can marshal to Ukraine to guarantee a truce negotiated without their

input.

Europeans already had four years of a Trump presidency. But many policymakers say that this time feels different, with four head-snapping weeks of Trump already recasting the attitudes of leaders who had vowed to make the best of his new term in office. “The view was a little bit more optimistic” just four weeks ago as Trump entered office, Finnish President Alexander Stubb told reporters Saturday.

“Of course, the developments that we’ve seen in the past few days give us a little bit more pause for pessimism. But as I’ve always said, pessimism is usually inac-

tion. Optimism is action, and realism is a solution,” he continued. “So let’s be realistic and try to look at a good pathway forward.”

Many Europeans are looking at the situation “with nervousness, frustration and even alarm,” said Jeffrey Rathke, the president of the American-German Institute at Johns Hopkins University and a former U.S. diplomat.

European foreign ministers who were in Munich over the weekend for an annual gathering of the transatlantic security elite

SEE EUROPE ON A7

Emergency meeting: Leaders seek influence in Ukraine talks. **A9**

‘Green lairds’ buying up vast estates in Scotland

Locals skeptical as to whether landowners’ selling of carbon credits is good for planet and country

BY WILLIAM BOOTH
IN TAYVALLICH, SCOTLAND

The Victorian elite prized their sporting estates in Scotland for the rarefied hunting and fishing — and the serious partying at their baronial mansions. The British royal family owns a classic one, called Balmoral Castle, more palace than castle. These vast holdings, burdened by history, are one reason so much land in Scotland is owned by so few.

Now, a new class of buyers is snapping up the fusty old estates, not so much for the grouse shooting or deer stalking but to pursue a more modern quarry: carbon credits.

Energy companies, private equity funds and beer brewers are among those who have become “natural capital” speculators in Scotland. The Scottish and British governments have encouraged these investments, incentivizing the planting of forests and the restoration of peatlands that can serve as carbon sinks, to soak up the emissions from the burning of coal, gas and oil that is warming the planet.

Some locals call the new own-



EMILY MACINNES/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Half the private rural land in Scotland is concentrated among 421 families, trusts and corporations. Many are planting forests, hoping to soak up the carbon that is warming Earth.

ers the “green lairds,” or lords. It is a dig that reflects skepticism about whether these projects are all that good for the planet, and whether further concentration of ownership is all that

good for Scotland.

It is an astounding data point, even to the Scots, that just 421 families, trusts and corporations hold title to half the private rural land in Scot-

land, according to the “Who Owns Scotland?” database compiled by Andy Wightman, a former Scottish lawmaker. Wightman said sales of big parcels

SEE SCOTLAND ON A10

DOGE seeks to access IRS data

REQUEST WORRIES TAX OFFICIALS

System includes sensitive taxpayer information

BY JACOB BOGAGE
AND JEFF STEIN

Elon Musk's U.S. DOGE Service is seeking access to a heavily-guarded Internal Revenue Service system that includes detailed financial information about every taxpayer, business and nonprofit in the country, according to three people familiar with the activities, sparking alarm within the tax agency.

Under pressure from the White House, the IRS is considering a memorandum of understanding that would give officials from DOGE — which stands for Department of Government Efficiency — broad access to tax-agency systems, property and datasets. Among them is the Integrated Data Retrieval System, or IDRS, which enables tax agency employees to access IRS accounts — including personal identification numbers — and bank information. It also lets them enter and adjust transaction data and automatically generate notices, collection documents and other records.

According to a draft of the memorandum obtained by The Washington Post, DOGE software engineer Gavin Kliger is set to

SEE IRS ON A4

In Denali, few favor an order from afar

President's restoration of Mount McKinley name leaves many perplexed

BY KARIN BRULLIARD

DENALI BOROUGH, ALASKA — Chris Noel is the mayor of Denali Borough and lives in the forested neighborhood of McKinley Village, which sometimes shows up as Denali Park on online maps. He's very accustomed to the dual identity that has long swirled around this region, the vast national park that defines it and the 20,310-foot crown jewel at its center.

But in this snow-shrouded land where the sun appears for only a few hours daily in winter, he and others say there is no disputing that the name of that mountain — North America's tallest — is the Indigenous word Denali. Never mind President Donald Trump's announcement just hours after his inauguration that he was restoring the behemoth peak's previous title of Mount McKinley, in honor of a turn-of-the-century president who never set foot in Alaska.

Noel hasn't heard a single resident express support.

“We prefer it to stay Denali,” he said, “and we're not going to change our name.”

SEE GUANTÁNAMO ON A16

IN THE NEWS

Control of government President Donald Trump asked the Supreme Court to allow him to fire the leader of an independent agency that investigates whistleblower reports. **A2**

NASA Much of the immediate future of the world's premier space agency may be in the hands of Elon Musk's U.S. DOGE Service. **A3**

THE NATION The acting archivist of the United States and several senior National Archives staff members have resigned. **A2**
Trump basked in the pomp and pageantry of the Daytona 500. **A4**

THE WORLD The freeze on U.S. foreign aid has left programs targeting security threats in limbo. **A6**
In Jerusalem, Marco Rubio warned Iran and praised Trump's plan for Gaza. **A9**

THE ECONOMY WikiTok is an internet rabbit hole that will actually make you smarter, Shira Ovide writes. **A13**

THE REGION A bill that would allow Arlington County to change its local government structure has not won the backing of the county board. **B1**

A racy silent-film star may have provided the inspiration for century-old graffiti beneath the Lincoln Memorial. **B1**
A special election to fill Trayon White Sr.'s former D.C. Council seat is set for July 15. **B1**
A lawsuit against the Landon School has been resolved before trial. **B1**

STYLE “Yellowjackets” actress Sophie Thatcher, fresh off the horror and sci-fi hits “Heretic” and “Companion,” embraces haunting roles. **C1**
Drake's new album of love songs is a failed attempt at damage control by the rapper, Chris Richards writes. **C1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A14
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A6

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54130

